

First-Time Dungeon Master

*A Step-by-Step System for Fast Prep, Better Encounters, and
Confident Improvisation*

by Cedric Darkstone

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Portions of this book were produced with the assistance of AI tools. The methods, templates, and text were reviewed and edited by the author.

How to use this book (and the templates)

You already know how to play. You've rolled the dice, made a character, argued about initiative order. Now you're on the other side of the screen, and it's a different job. This book teaches that job, and only that job. It does not re-explain what a d20 is or how a saving throw works. You have that already. If you don't, one read of the starter rules covers it, and then you come back here.

Every chapter answers one problem a first-time DM has, in the order you hit it: your first session, fast prep, session zero, rulings, improvisation, NPCs, encounters, locations, pacing, table trouble, and turning one night into a campaign. Two later chapters cover playing online and handing out treasure, and the appendices give you two finished adventures, a starter bestiary, and tables to build your own. Read it front to back once. After that, treat it as a toolbox. Open the chapter for the problem in front of you.

The spine of the book is the templates. Each chapter ends with a fillable sheet that turns what you just read into something you can use at the table tonight. Copy them, print them, scribble on them. A blank, printable pack of every template in this book is waiting at the link on the last page. The book teaches the method. The templates carry it into your game.

One promise before you start: you can run a good first session without being a good DM yet. Confidence at the table is a set of skills, and skills are built by doing, not by reading one more chapter. This book gets you doing fast.

Turn the page. Your first session starts now.

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Part I

Run Your First Session

Chapter 1: Your First Session Starts Now

Your group is looking at you. The snacks are out, the dice are on the table, and someone says, "Okay, so what do we do?" That moment is the whole job. Not the lore you wrote, not the map you drew. The moment you say the first sentence and the game begins.

Most first-time DMs try to be ready for everything before that moment. They read the whole rulebook, build a world with five kingdoms, and stat out a villain the players will not meet for a year. Then session one arrives and none of it helps, because the players walk left when the notes went right. You do not need to be ready for everything. You need five things. This chapter is those five things, and nothing else.

The five things you need

A place to start, and a reason to care. Your players need somewhere to be and a problem in front of them on the first line. A tavern is not a start. A tavern with a frightened messenger who dies before he finishes his sentence is a start. Give them a scene with trouble already in it.

A goal for tonight. One clear thing the players could do in this session. Find the missing child. Clear the cellar. Reach the next town alive. It does not have to be what they end up doing. It gives the night a shape and gives you something to steer back toward when the table drifts.

Three names and three faces. Someone will ask "who's the innkeeper?" and you will freeze. Beat that now. Have three names ready and give each person one thing you can play: a stutter, a grudge, a limp. That is enough to make an NPC (a non-player character, anyone the players talk to who isn't a player) feel real.

One thing that can go wrong. A fight, a trap, a betrayal. One planned moment of danger gives the session a spike of tension and gives the players something to beat. You will build encounters properly in Chapter 7. For tonight, one is enough.

A way to say yes. Your most-used tool is not a rule. It is the habit of taking what a player tries and building on it instead of blocking it. "Can I check the body for a letter?" Yes. Now there's a letter. You decide what it says. Saying yes keeps the table moving and keeps the story theirs.

That is the list. Notice what is not on it. No world map. No pantheon. No twelve-step backstory for the villain. Those are fun to make and they will not save your first session. The five things will.

Fear is the tax, not the wall

Here is the truth no one tells a new DM plainly. Yes, the players will do something you did not plan. They will talk to the barrel, romance the guard, and ignore the door you spent an hour describing. That is not a sign you failed to prepare. That is the game working. A tabletop game the players cannot surprise is a book, not a game.

So expect the swerve and stop fearing it. When it comes, you fall back on the five things and the habit of yes. The rest of this book gives you a tool for each kind of swerve: a way to make a ruling on the spot, a table to invent an NPC in ten seconds, a method to build a fight fast. You are not walking in unarmed. You are walking in with a kit, and you are about to learn to use it.

At a real table

Taka is running her first session for four friends. She skips the world map and fills the five slots. The players start in a mill where the miller's daughter has just been dragged into the river by something with too many arms. Tonight's goal is to get her back. Her three NPCs are a shaking miller, a smug town reeve, and a hedge-witch who knows the river. One danger: the thing in the water. When a player says "I jump in

after her," Taka does not reach for a rule. She says yes, sets the stakes, and calls for a Strength check. Twenty minutes in, nobody has noticed she has no map, because the trouble was on the first line and the table has been chasing it ever since.

***At the table:** when your mind goes blank, ask the players a question. "What does your character do?" hands the moment back to them and buys you the three seconds you need to think. A DM who asks good questions looks more prepared than one who talks the most.*

Do this before your first session

Fill the checklist below. It should take fifteen minutes, and it replaces every hour you were about to spend reading rules you will not use tonight. When the five slots are full, you are ready. Not ready for everything. Ready for this.

The First-Session Checklist

Fill one before session one. Blank copy in the download pack (last page).

FIRST SESSION: _____ DATE: _____

1 - THE OPENING SCENE

Where they start: _____

The trouble already happening: _____

First line I say out loud: _____

2 - TONIGHT'S GOAL

One thing they could accomplish: _____

3 - THREE NPCs

Name _____ - one trait _____

Name _____ - one trait _____

Name _____ - one trait _____

4 - ONE DANGER

What can go wrong: _____

Where/when it hits: _____

5 - MY SAFETY LINE

If I freeze, I will ask: "What does your character do?"

You have a session in a box. Next you'll learn how to fill that box in under an hour, every time, without the Wednesday-night dread.

Chapter 2: The One-Hour Prep System

It's Wednesday. You play Saturday. Between now and then you have a job, a life, and a slow dread that says you're not ready.

Most first-time DMs fall into the same trap. They open the rulebook "to prepare" and three hours later they've read about siege weapons, planar travel, and a table for random tavern names, none of which their players will touch on Saturday. They mistake reading for prep. Then Saturday comes, and they cancel.

You're not going to do that. You're going to prep the whole session in one hour, using the same six steps every time. Set a timer. When the hour is up, you stop. A session prepped in an hour and run with confidence beats a "perfect" session that never happens.

One rule before we start: **prep the first fifteen minutes of play in detail, and sketch the rest.** Players are unpredictable. The opening scene is the only part you control, so make it sharp. Everything after that, you improvise from a few strong notes. That's the skill the rest of this book builds.

The six steps (and the clock)

Each step has a time budget. The budget matters more than the polish. If a step runs long, cut it off and move on. You can always add detail later. You can never get Saturday back.

Step 1. The strong open (15 minutes). Write the first scene as if it were the first page of a movie. Where are the players? What's happening the moment you say "we begin"? Give them something to react to on line one: a scream down the hall, or a stranger who already knows their names. Not "you're all in a tavern." A tavern is a place. You need an

event. Write three sentences: the setup, the trouble, and the choice the players face. That's your open. Fifteen minutes, done.

Step 2. The want (5 minutes). Name what your villain or problem *wants*, in one sentence. Not their backstory. Their want. "The cult wants to wake the thing under the lake." A want gives every scene a direction, because the world keeps moving toward it whether the players act or not. If you know the want, you can improvise the rest.

Step 3. Three beats (10 minutes). Sketch three things that could happen, in the loosest possible form. A place they might go, a person they might meet, a fight they might pick. Three bullet points, a line each. Do not script them. These are ingredients, not a plot. If the players skip all three, you've lost ten minutes, not ten hours.

Step 4. One fight, roughed in (15 minutes). You'll likely have one combat. Pick the monsters now so you're not flipping pages mid-game. Write down their names, how many, and where the fight happens. Don't do the math on balance yet. Chapter 7 gives you a formula for that in ten minutes. For now, choose, and note the page number where each monster's stats live.

Step 5. Names and faces (10 minutes). The one thing that will catch you flat-footed is a player asking a nameless shopkeeper, "So who are you?" Prep kills that panic. Write five names now. Give three of them a single quirk: a limp, a nervous laugh, a grudge. When a player talks to someone you didn't plan, you grab a name off the list and you're never caught empty.

Step 6. The safety net (5 minutes). Write down three things you always forget in the moment: where you left the last session, what the players said they'd do next, and one reward they can find if they get stuck. This is the note you'll reach for during play.

Add it up: fifteen, five, ten, fifteen, ten, five. One hour. Stop when it's done.

At a real table

It is 8:40 on a Tuesday and Marcus has twenty minutes before bed. He sets a timer and runs the six steps. Strong open: bandits have strung a rope across the forest road and are robbing a merchant when the party rides up. The want: the bandit chief needs coin to pay off a worse enemy. Then three beats, one fight roughed in, five names, a safety-net note. The timer beeps at nine. He closes the notebook with a session ready and his evening back. On Saturday the players ignore the merchant entirely and chase the bandits home, and it does not matter, because Marcus prepped a situation, not a script.

At the table: keep the safety-net note (Step 6) on top of your pile. When the game stalls and your mind goes blank, look there first. It's the fastest way back into the story.

Why an hour is enough

New DMs over-prepare because prep feels safe and running the game feels scary. But the players never see your prep. They see how you handle the table: your rulings, your improvisation, the way you keep things moving. Those are table skills, not paper skills, and no amount of extra prep buys them. Preparing less forces you to build the skills that matter, and this book builds them with you.

There's a second reason. A session you scripted to the minute breaks the moment the players go off-script. And they will, on line one. A session built from six strong notes bends instead. You're not memorizing a play. You're packing a kit.

So next Wednesday, set the timer. Run the six steps. Close the book when the hour's up, and go live your life until Saturday. You're readier than you think.

The 1-Hour Prep Worksheet

Fill one before every session. Blank copy in the download pack (last page).

SESSION #: _____ DATE: _____ TIME BUDGET: 60 min

1 - STRONG OPEN (15m)

Setup: _____

Trouble: _____

The choice they face: _____

2 - THE WANT (5m)

The villain/problem wants: _____

3 - THREE BEATS (10m) (ingredients, not a plot)

- _____
- _____
- _____

4 - ONE FIGHT (15m)

Monsters + number: _____

Where: _____

Stat page refs: _____

5 - NAMES & FACES (10m)

Names: __ / __ / __ / __ / __

Quirks (x3): _____

6 - SAFETY NET (5m)

Last session ended with: _____

Players said they'd: _____

If stuck, they can find: _____

Prep is handled. Next you'll learn to run the table itself, starting with the fear every new DM names first: getting a rule wrong.

Chapter 3: Session Zero Without the Awkwardness

Half of the problems that wreck a campaign are set on the first night, before a single die is rolled. One player wants a grim war story. Another wants to make jokes and rob shopkeepers. Someone assumed there would be no killing of good characters, and nobody checked. None of them are wrong. They never said what they wanted out loud.

A session zero (the meeting before you play, where the table agrees on what the game is) fixes this in one sitting. It is not a rules lecture and it should not feel like a form to fill out. Done well, it takes forty minutes, gets everyone talking, and hands you a map of what your players actually want. Here is how to run one without the room going quiet and weird.

Set the frame first

Start by saying what kind of game you are offering, in two sentences. "I'm thinking a grounded fantasy about a frontier town in trouble. More problem-solving than dungeon-crawling, some combat, room for your characters' pasts to matter." You are not asking permission. You are giving the table something to react to, the same way you give the players a scene with trouble already in it. A frame invites a yes or a "can we tweak this," and both are useful.

Then hand the game to them with three questions. Ask each player: what does your character want, what are they afraid of, and why would they leave home to do this? Keep the answers short. You are not writing novels. You are collecting hooks, one per player, that you will pull on all campaign.

Agree on the table's edges

Every group has lines. Some tables are fine with horror and betrayal. Some are not. Finding out mid-scene, when a player goes pale, is the worst possible time. So ask now, plainly and without drama: is anything off the table for us? Common ones are harm to children, graphic torture, and real-world bigotry played straight. Write down what comes up. Nobody has to explain why. "That's a no for me" is a full sentence.

Add two practical agreements while you have everyone. How does the group make decisions when they disagree, and what happens when someone has to miss a session. Deciding these cold, in five calm minutes, saves you an ugly argument later when tempers are up.

Tie their characters together

The single most common first-campaign failure is five strangers with no reason to stay in the same room. Fix it before you play. Give the group two minutes to answer one question together: how do at least two of you already know each other? A shared debt, a sibling, a war they both survived. You do not need a web connecting everyone. You need enough thread that the party is a party on line one, not a collection of loners who happen to share a table.

Close by pointing at the hooks you collected. "Kesh, your character wants to find the brother who vanished. That's going to matter early." You are telling each player their choices were heard, and you are quietly promising a game built around them. That promise is why they come back for session two.

At a real table

Before his first campaign, Devi spends forty minutes on a session zero. He offers a frame: a mining town where the deep tunnels have gone quiet. He asks each player the three questions and learns one wants revenge, one wants to get rich and leave, one is running from family. He asks about table edges, and a player quietly says no torture, thank you.

Devi writes it down without a word. Two characters turn out to be estranged cousins. By the time dice come out, the party has a reason to be together and Devi has four hooks he will pull for months. The campaign is built before it starts.

***At the table:** keep your session-zero notes in front of you during play, not filed away. When the game sags, pull a player's stated fear or want into the scene. Nothing re-grabs a distracted table faster than making its own answers come true.*

Turn the talk into a plan

The template below turns forty minutes of conversation into one page you will use for the whole campaign. Fill it with the group, out loud, so everyone sees their answers go down. That page is your first real prep, and it is worth more than any map.

The Session Zero Agenda

Fill with the group. Blank copy in the download pack (last page).

CAMPAIGN: _____ DATE: _____

THE FRAME (you fill this first, before the meeting)

Kind of game, in two sentences: _____

Tone: light __ / mixed __ / grim __

EACH PLAYER (one line each)

Player _____ Character _____

Wants: _____ Fears: _____ Left home because: _____
(repeat per player)

TABLE EDGES

Off the table for us: _____

How we decide when we disagree: _____

When someone misses a session: _____

THE PARTY BOND

How two of them already know each other: _____

HOOKS I WILL PULL EARLY (copy from above)

- _____
- _____

Your table now agrees on the game before the game starts. Next you'll handle the fear that keeps most new DMs up at night: what to do when

you don't know the rule.

Part II

Handle the Table

Chapter 4: Rulings, Not Rules

A player says, "I want to swing on the chandelier and kick the guard off the balcony." Everyone looks at you. There is no page for this. Your heart rate climbs, and some part of you wants to flip through the book to find the swinging-on-chandeliers rule. There isn't one. There does not need to be one. What the table needs is a decision, and you are allowed to make it.

This is the fear that keeps new DMs up at night: getting a rule wrong in front of people who know the game better than you. Here is the reframe that ends it. Your job is not to remember every rule. Your job is to make a fair, fast ruling and keep the game moving. A ruling is a call you make on the spot when the rules are silent, unclear, or too slow to look up. Good DMs make dozens a night. Nobody at the table can tell the difference between a rule you knew and a ruling you invented, as long as it was fair.

The four-step ruling

When you hit a moment the rules do not cover, run these four steps in your head. They take about five seconds with practice.

Ask what they're really trying to do. Not the stunt, the goal. Swinging on the chandelier is the how. Knocking the guard off the balcony is the what. Rule on the what. This one question dissolves most rules confusion, because a clear goal usually points at a clear check.

Pick the obvious check. Match the goal to an ability the player already has on their sheet. A daring physical stunt is Strength or Dexterity. Talking someone down is Charisma. Noticing a lie is Wisdom. You are not finding the "correct" check. You are finding a reasonable one.

Reasonable is enough.

Set the stakes before the roll. Say what happens on a success and what happens on a failure, out loud, before dice hit the table. "Hit it and the guard goes over the rail. Miss and you're hanging there, exposed, and he gets a free swing at you." Now the roll means something and the player chose it with eyes open.

Let the dice land and move on. Whatever the roll says, narrate it and push forward. Do not reopen the ruling to check whether you did it "right." A ruling made and honored beats a rule looked up over three quiet minutes while the table checks their phones.

When a player says you got it wrong

Sometimes the rules lawyer at your table is correct, and says so mid-scene. Have one response ready: "Good catch. We'll use the real rule from here. For this roll, we'll keep what we said." This does three things. It thanks them, it fixes the future, and it protects the flow of the current moment. Say it once and mean it, and even the most rules-focused player will settle, because you gave their knowledge a place to go.

Never rule to punish a clever idea. If a player finds a way to make a fight easier or skip a trap you were proud of, that is not cheating. That is the game working. Reward the cleverness and build the next challenge harder. A table learns fast whether its DM says yes to good ideas or looks for reasons to say no, and that lesson decides how bold your players will be for the rest of the campaign.

At a real table

A player wants to tip a bookshelf onto a charging cultist. There is no bookshelf-tipping rule. Priya runs the four steps in her head. The goal is to stop the charge, Strength fits, and she says the stakes out loud. "Beat a 15 and he's pinned and prone. Miss and you're off balance, and he gets there first." The player rolls a 17, the shelf comes down, the table cheers.

Later a rules-focused player mentions the official way to handle improvised attacks. "Good catch," Priya says. "Real rule from here. This one stands." Nobody could tell she invented the whole thing on the spot.

***At the table:** when in doubt, make a ruling and add "we'll confirm after the session." It keeps the game moving now and gives you a clean way to look up the real rule later, without a five-minute stall while everyone waits on you.*

Your ruling cheat-sheet

The sheet below is not a template you fill before play. It is a reference you keep open during play, for the moment your mind blanks. Copy it, tape it inside your screen, and glance at it the first few sessions until the four steps are automatic.

The "When in Doubt" Ruling Sheet

Keep this open during play. Printable copy in the download pack (last page).

A PLAYER TRIES SOMETHING THE RULES DON'T COVER:

- 1 - WHAT are they really trying to do? (goal, not stunt)
- 2 - WHICH ability fits?
 - Force/stunt Strength or Dexterity
 - Talk/charm Charisma
 - Notice/sense Wisdom
 - Recall/figure out . Intelligence
 - Endure/hold on Constitution
- 3 - STAKES out loud:
 - On success: _____ On failure: _____
- 4 - ROLL, narrate, move on. Confirm the real rule after the session.

DIFFICULTY, FAST:

Easy 10 - Medium 15 - Hard 20
(When unsure, use 15.)

IF A PLAYER CORRECTS YOU:

"Good catch. Real rule from here. This roll stands."

You can now handle any rule you don't know without stopping the game. Next is the bigger fear underneath it: what to do when the players go somewhere you built nothing for.

Chapter 5: Confident Improvisation

The players just walked into a shop you never planned, to ask a shopkeeper who does not exist about a rumor you never wrote. This is the moment every new DM dreads, and it happens every single session. You cannot prep your way out of it. There are infinite things five creative people might do, and you will never guess them all. So you stop trying to guess, and you learn to build on the spot instead.

Improvisation is not a gift some DMs are born with. It is a set of small moves and a few tables you can lean on until the moves become instinct. This chapter gives you both. By the end you will trust that whatever the players throw at you, you can catch it and throw something back.

The one habit: yes, and

Improv comedy runs on two words, and they work at a game table too. When a player offers something, take it and add to it. "Is there a back door?" Yes, and it's chained from the outside, which is strange. "Do I know this guard?" Yes, and you owe him money. The player hands you a gift every time they ask a question or try an action. Your job is to accept it and raise. Blocking, the habit of answering "no, there's nothing," starves the scene and teaches players to stop trying.

There is a cousin move for when yes would break your story: yes, but. "Can I persuade the king to send his army?" Yes, but he wants your character's family name as collateral. The players still get a path forward, and you get a complication that makes the next scene. Between yes and, and yes but, you almost never have to say a flat no.

When your mind goes blank, roll

Nobody improvises well under a spotlight with an empty head. That is what the tables below are for. When a player asks for something you did not prepare, do not scramble. Roll a d20 (the twenty-sided die) on the matching table, read the result, and say it with confidence. The players will never know you did not plan it. Over time you will stop needing the tables, because you will have internalized the range of answers they hold. Until then, they are your net.

Use them live. Keep them where you can see them. And feel free to swap any entry for one that fits your world better. The point is to never sit in silence.

The improv tables

Roll a d20. Printable copies of all four in the download pack (last page).

TABLE A – WHO IS THIS NPC? (you need a person, now)

- 1 A nervous clerk hiding a small theft
- 2 A retired soldier who talks too much
- 3 A widow running the family trade alone
- 4 A smug official expecting a bribe
- 5 A cheerful liar who knows everyone
- 6 A frightened youth in over their head
- 7 A blunt laborer with no patience
- 8 A traveling peddler with strange goods
- 9 A local drunk who saw something real
- 10 A devout believer sure of a sign
- 11 A grieving parent looking for someone
- 12 A rival who remembers an old slight
- 13 A gossip trading secrets for coin
- 14 A guard who hates their job
- 15 A healer short on supplies
- 16 A collector obsessed with one object
- 17 A former criminal trying to go straight
- 18 A stern elder guarding tradition
- 19 A charmer working an angle
- 20 An outsider who fears the locals

TABLE B – WHAT COMPLICATES THIS SCENE?

- 1 Someone is watching from the shadows
- 2 A rival group wants the same thing
- 3 The information is true but incomplete
- 4 A price is attached that hurts
- 5 The wrong person overhears
- 6 Time is shorter than they thought
- 7 An old enemy is involved
- 8 A lie unravels at the worst moment
- 9 The weather or terrain turns against them
- 10 A trusted contact has switched sides
- 11 Reinforcements are on the way
- 12 The target has already fled
- 13 A trap was set for someone else
- 14 A debt comes due right now
- 15 Two goals suddenly conflict
- 16 A witness demands something to talk
- 17 The path forward is guarded
- 18 Someone recognizes a character
- 19 The reward is not what was promised
- 20 A sound draws unwanted attention

TABLE C – YES, AND / YES, BUT (how does the world answer?)

Roll d20. 1-12 = "yes, and" (a bonus): pick or invent an upside.

13-19 = "yes, but" (a cost): pick or invent a complication.

20 = "yes, and" plus a lucky break that opens a new path.

(Reserve a flat no only for the physically impossible.)

TABLE D – INSTANT NAMES (grab one, cross it off)

Common: Bren - Kesh - Mira - Doran - Sela - Tomas

Grand: Aurelian - Vespera - Castellán - Ysolde

Rough: Grud - Nix - Halla - Bricktop - Vane - Sump

At a real table

The party strolls into a temple Sam never wrote and asks the priest about a stolen relic. Sam has no priest. He rolls on Table A and gets "a devout believer sure of a sign," grabs the name Ysolde, and gives her a want: she thinks the theft is a test from her god. When the players press for details, Sam rolls Table B, gets "true but incomplete," and has Ysolde send them to the wrong suspect in complete good faith. The scene crackles, the players argue about whether to trust her, and Sam writes "Ysolde" on his keeper list. She was born from two dice and is now a recurring character.

***At the table:** repeat the player's idea back before you answer it. "You want to bluff the guard into thinking you're his new captain." Saying it out loud buys three seconds, confirms you heard right, and often the table fills the silence with details you can steal.*

Keep the ones that stick

When an improvised NPC or complication lands well, write it down after the session. Bren the nervous clerk who was supposed to appear once becomes a recurring favorite because you kept the note.

Improvisation feeds your prep, and your prep frees you to improvise. That loop, not a thicker binder, is what makes a confident DM.

The Improv Toolkit

Assemble your live sheet before the session. Printable copy in the download pack.

IMPROV TOOLKIT – keep open during play

FIRST MOVE, ALWAYS: repeat it back, then "yes, and" / "yes, but"
BLANK ON A PERSON? roll Table A, add one trait, give a name from Table D
SCENE TOO EASY? roll Table B for a complication
WORLD'S ANSWER? roll Table C

NPCs I INVENTED TONIGHT (write down the keepers):

Name _____ who they are _____ where met _____
Name _____ who they are _____ where met _____

You can now catch anything the players throw. Next you'll make the people they meet worth remembering, in a single line.

Chapter 6: NPCs Your Players Remember

Ask any group about their favorite campaign moment and half the time it is a person, not a battle. The paranoid shopkeeper. The knight who quoted bad poetry. The villain who was almost sympathetic. Players remember characters. And here is the good news for a new DM: a memorable NPC takes one line, not one page. The DMs who write three paragraphs of backstory are doing more work for a worse result.

An NPC (a non-player character, anyone the players talk to who isn't a player) needs exactly three things to come alive at the table: a want, a trait, and a voice you can do. Backstory is optional and mostly for you. What the players feel is those three things, delivered in the moment. This chapter makes each of them fast.

A want, so they push

Every NPC on stage should want something in the scene, even something small. The merchant wants to close before dark. The guard wants to avoid trouble on his watch. The want gives you a way to play the NPC without a script, because you always know what they are trying to get. When a player talks to them, you have the NPC pursue the want, and the scene writes itself. An NPC with no want stands there like furniture and the conversation dies.

A trait, so they stick

One vivid, playable trait is what the players remember. Not a list. One. A twitchy eye, a habit of flattering everyone, a refusal to make eye contact, a laugh at the wrong moments. Pick something you can show through action and speech, not something you have to narrate. "He keeps glancing at the door" tells the players more than "he is anxious," and it

gives them something to poke at.

A voice you can do

You do not need to be an actor. You need contrast, so the players can tell one NPC from another. Change one dial: talk faster, drop to a near-whisper, clip your sentences short, add a verbal tic they repeat. A single consistent choice reads as a full character. If a voice feels like too much in front of your group, use posture and phrasing instead. The blunt laborer says "what do you want" while the oily official says "ah, how may I be of service." Same information, different person.

Reuse without the players noticing

You will not invent every NPC fresh. Good DMs keep a short stable of people they can drop into any town: a fixer, a healer, a bully, a source of rumors. When the players need a face you did not plan, you pull one from the stable, rename it, and adjust one trait. The missing-child plot in this town and the smuggling plot in the next can both use "the tired guard who wants an easy shift," and no one will ever know it was the same sketch.

At a real table

The party needs a smith. Lin does not narrate a biography. She gives him a want (close early, his kid is sick), a trait (wipes his hands on the same rag over and over), and one dial (clipped, tired sentences). "Make it quick. What do you need." A player mentions the sick child they overheard about, and Lin has the smith soften, a little. Three sessions later the players still call him "the rag guy" and go out of their way to help him. He took one line to build and he outlived half the plot Lin actually planned.

***At the table:** give the NPC an opinion about the players before they speak. A stranger who already likes or distrusts the party turns a flat "how can I help you" into a scene with tension in it, and it costs you nothing to decide on the spot.*

Write the one line, not the page

The card below is the whole method. Fill it in one line per NPC for the handful of people you know the players will meet, and leave blanks to fill live with the tables from Chapter 5 for everyone else. A stack of these one-line cards is worth more than a document of NPC biographies you will never open at the table.

The 1-Line NPC Card

One card per named NPC. Printable copy in the download pack (last page).

NPC CARD

Name: _____ Where the players meet them: _____

WANT (in this scene): _____

TRAIT (one, playable): _____

VOICE (one dial to turn): _____
[] faster [] whisper [] clipped [] verbal tic: _____

OPINION OF THE PARTY: likes __ / neutral __ / distrusts __

ONE SECRET OR HOOK (optional): _____

Your players will now meet people they remember. Next you'll give those people something to fight over, and learn to build a balanced encounter in ten minutes.

Part III

Build the Adventure

Chapter 7: Build an Encounter in Ten Minutes

Two fights go wrong for new DMs, and they are opposites. In the first, the monsters fall over in one round and the players shrug. In the second, a random pack of wolves nearly kills the whole party and everyone goes quiet. Both come from the same source: guessing at difficulty instead of measuring it. You do not need deep math to measure it. You need a rough budget and a danger dial, and you can set both in ten minutes.

Ignore the temptation to calculate exact challenge ratings mid-prep. The official math is fine and slow. What follows is a fast heuristic that lands close enough to run a tense, fair fight, which is all a first-time DM needs. Tune it up over a few sessions as you learn your group.

The budget: threat points

Give your party a threat budget based on its size and level. Then spend that budget on monsters. Roughly, one "threat point" is a monster whose level (its challenge rating, the game's difficulty number for a monster, written CR) equals your players' level. A CR-2 monster against level-2 heroes is one point. Two of them is two points.

Here is the whole rule. For a standard fight, the budget equals the number of players. Four players, four points, and you spend it on monsters near their level. Want a hard fight? Spend one and a half times the players. Want an easy warm-up? Spend half. That is the entire formula, and it is close enough.

The trick with the budget is spread. Four CR-1 monsters and one CR-4 monster both cost about four points against a level-4 party, but they play completely differently. Many weak monsters threaten to overwhelm and

swing wildly. One big monster is predictable and can be focused down. Mixing a mid-size threat with a couple of minions gives you the best fights, because the players have choices about what to hit first.

The danger dial: three levers

The budget sets the size of the fight. Three levers set how dangerous it feels, and you turn them at the table without touching the numbers.

Terrain. A flat empty room is the least interesting fight in the game. Add one feature the players and monsters both use: a chasm to shove enemies into, cover to hide behind, a fire spreading each round. Terrain does more for tension than an extra monster.

Numbers over time. A fight that starts hard and stays hard is exhausting. A fight where two more enemies arrive on round three, unless the players do something about the alarm bell, has a built-in clock and a built-in choice. Reinforcements are a dial you can turn up or down live, based on how the party is holding.

An exit. Players fight harder and panic less when losing does not mean dying. Give most fights a way out: a door to flee through, a foe who takes prisoners, a chance to surrender. Save the no-escape fight for a moment you have built toward, and it will land much harder for being rare.

At a real table

Four players at level three walk into an ambush. Reese sets a standard budget of four points: one CR-2 bandit captain and four weak thugs, spread so the captain is the real threat. He turns one danger lever, a rain-slick bridge both sides can shove enemies off. The fight swings when a thug goes over the rail and the captain, seeing it turn, tries to flee. Reese lets him, because he built an exit. Nobody dies, everyone burned resources, and the captain escapes to become next month's problem. A fair fight, built in ten minutes, that fed the campaign.

***At the table:** watch the party's resources, not their hit points, to judge a fight. If they are winning but burning spells and potions fast, the fight is doing its job. Attrition across a session is scarier and fairer than one deadly encounter that can end a character to a bad roll.*

Rough it in, then run it

The worksheet below is what "ten minutes" looks like. Set the budget, pick a spread of monsters, turn one or two danger levers, and note where the stat blocks live so you are not flipping pages mid-fight. You are not designing a perfect encounter. You are building a fair one fast, and leaving yourself room to adjust while it plays.

The Encounter Balance Worksheet

Fill before a planned fight. Printable copy in the download pack (last page).

ENCOUNTER: _____ PARTY: ____ players at level ____

1 - BUDGET (threat points)

Easy = half the players Standard = players Hard = players x1.5
This fight is: easy ____ / standard ____ / hard ____ -> budget = ____

2 - SPEND IT (aim for a spread, not all identical)

Monster _____ CR ____ x ____ ≈ ____ pts stat page ____
Monster _____ CR ____ x ____ ≈ ____ pts stat page ____
Monster _____ CR ____ x ____ ≈ ____ pts stat page ____
Total points: ____ (compare to budget above)

3 - DANGER DIAL (turn at least one)

Terrain feature both sides use: _____
Reinforcements arrive if: _____
The way out is: _____

4 - WHAT THEY GET FOR WINNING: _____

You can now build a fair fight fast. Next you'll give that fight a place to happen, and learn to make a dungeon on demand.

Chapter 8: Dungeons and Locations on Demand

A player says, "We go down into the old crypt." You had a name and nothing else. Now you need a place, with rooms and danger and a reason to go in, and you need it in the next thirty seconds. New DMs freeze here because they think a dungeon is a hand-drawn map with forty numbered rooms. It is not. A dungeon is five rooms with a point, and you can build one at the table.

This chapter gives you a template that fits almost any location the players enter: a crypt, a bandit fort, a wizard's tower, a haunted mansion. Same five beats, different paint. Learn it once and you will never be caught empty when the party opens a door you did not plan.

The five-room shape

A satisfying location has a shape, not only rooms in a row. This one has five beats, and they can bend around whatever map you sketch.

The entrance, with a guardian. The way in should cost something: a lock, a lookout, a puzzle, a warning. It tells the players they have crossed into danger and sets the tone.

The puzzle or roleplay challenge. A room that is not solved by fighting. A riddle, a trapped hall, a prisoner who will talk, a choice between two doors. This is where the players who do not love combat get their moment.

The setback. Something goes wrong here. A trap they trip, an ambush, the floor gives way, a betrayal. The setback drains resources and raises the stakes before the climax.

The climax. The reason the place exists. The boss, the sealed vault, the ritual about to complete. Everything before this was building toward it, and the players should feel that.

The reward and the twist. They win, and they get something: treasure, an ally, the information they came for. Attach one twist that points at what comes next. The stolen ledger names a bigger villain. The freed prisoner has a warning. The reward opens the next adventure.

Paint it in one pass

Once you know the five beats, you dress them. Pick a theme, then ask what each beat looks like in that theme. A crypt's guardian is a sealed stone door and a warning carved in old script. A bandit fort's guardian is a lookout on the wall. Same beat, different paint. You can do this out loud while the players describe their approach, and it will feel authored, because the shape underneath is doing the work.

You do not need a grid map for most locations. A rough sketch of five connected spaces, or even a list of five rooms, runs fine as long as you can tell the players what they see and what their choices are. Draw a proper map only when the exact geometry matters, like a fight where positioning is the whole point.

At a real table

"We go into the old lighthouse," a player says, and Noor has a name and nothing else. She fills the five beats live. Entrance: a rusted door chained from inside, so someone is here. Puzzle: a room of mirrors that must be turned toward the sea. Setback: the stairs collapse behind them. Climax: a smuggler-mage finishing a signal-spell at the top. Reward and twist: the treasure is a ledger naming a councilwoman the party trusts. Noor drew nothing but a stack of five boxes on scrap paper, and the players will talk about the lighthouse for weeks.

***At the table:** describe every new room in three quick strokes: what you see, what you hear or smell, and the one thing that invites action. "Cold water to*

your ankles, a drip echoing somewhere ahead, and a rusted grate in the far wall that's been pried open recently." Three strokes give a room life without a paragraph.

Build the crawl in five lines

The sheet below turns a location name into a runnable dungeon in the time it takes the party to light a torch. Fill the five beats, add a theme, and you have a place with a point. For locations you know the players will visit, prep one ahead. For the ones they surprise you with, fill it live, one beat at a time as they move.

The 5-Room Dungeon Sheet

One per location. Printable copy in the download pack (last page).

LOCATION: _____ THEME/PAINT: _____
WHY THE PARTY COMES HERE: _____

- 1 - ENTRANCE + GUARDIAN
The cost to get in: _____
- 2 - PUZZLE / ROLEPLAY CHALLENGE
Solved without fighting by: _____
- 3 - THE SETBACK
What goes wrong: _____
- 4 - THE CLIMAX
The reason this place exists: _____
- 5 - REWARD + TWIST
They gain: _____ The twist that points ahead: _____

Your party can open any door and find a place ready for them. Next you'll keep the story moving between those places, so the game never stalls out.

Chapter 9: Keep the Story Moving

There is a specific silence every new DM learns to dread. The players have finished a scene, they look at each other, and someone says, "So... what do we do now?" Nobody knows where to go. The energy leaks out of the room. You built a world and the party is standing in it, lost. This is a pacing problem, and pacing is a skill you can learn as cleanly as any rule.

Two failures cause most stalls. Either the players do not know what they could do next, or they know but cannot find the way. This chapter fixes both, and it does it without railroading, which is the trap on the other side: dragging players down the one path you prepared and punishing them for stepping off it. The goal is a game that flows and still belongs to the players.

Never hide the next step behind one roll

The most common stall is a mystery gated behind a single check. The clue is in the study, the players roll to search, they fail, and now the story cannot continue because the information is trapped behind a die. Avoid this with a simple habit: any fact the plot needs, the players find automatically. Rolls decide how much extra they get, not whether the story moves.

The clean version of this is the three-clue rule. For any conclusion you need the players to reach, plant three separate paths to it. Three witnesses, three pieces of evidence, three ways to learn the cult meets at midnight. Players are inventive and will miss two of anything. With three, they almost always find one, and they feel clever instead of stuck, because they think they solved it rather than followed your rail.

When they stall anyway, apply pressure

Sometimes the party has the information and still spins in place, debating options in a town while the game idles. Do not wait them out. Make the world act. A clock the villain is racing gives every idle minute a cost. A messenger arrives with news that forces a choice. The thing they were deciding whether to investigate happens to someone else. When the players will not move the story, move the story at them, and watch the table snap back to life.

Pressure is also how you handle the party that scatters to do five things at once. Instead of tracking five threads, tell them the world will not wait: the festival is tonight, the caravan leaves at dawn, the ritual completes at the new moon. A shared deadline pulls a scattered party back into one story without you forcing them onto a path.

Give every scene a turn

A scene that ends where it began is a scene that saps momentum. Aim for each one to change something: the players learn a fact, gain or lose an ally, or the situation gets worse. If you notice a scene is only the players confirming what they already knew, cut to the next thing. You are allowed to say "an hour passes, and then" and skip the boring part. New DMs narrate every step. Confident DMs cut to where the choices are.

At a real table

The party stalls, arguing in the market about whether the disappearances are worth their time. Ari does not wait. He starts the clock he prepped: a child screams two streets over, and by the time they arrive, another person is gone. The debate is over. Earlier Ari made sure the key fact, that the cult meets at midnight, had three paths to it: a witness, a dropped token, and a pattern in the dates. The party found the token, missed the other two, and felt like detectives. The story moved, and they never saw the rails, because there were three of them.

***At the table:** end each session on a question, not a rest. Stop the moment a door creaks open, a letter arrives, or a stranger says their name. A cliffhanger does two jobs: it makes the group hungry for next time, and it hands you an obvious opening scene for your one-hour prep.*

Map the path, keep it open

The one-page tool below is not a plot you force. It is a safety net that guarantees the players can always find a next step and always feel the pressure of a moving world. Fill the clues so no fact is trapped behind one roll, set a clock so idling has a cost, and note where you can cut when a scene runs flat.

The Adventure One-Page

One per adventure or arc. Printable copy in the download pack (last page).

ADVENTURE: _____ THE PARTY'S GOAL: _____

THE THREE-CLUE RULE (the key fact the players must reach)

Key fact: _____

Clue path 1: _____

Clue path 2: _____

Clue path 3: _____

THE CLOCK (why idling costs them)

The villain/world is racing to: _____

What happens if the party waits: _____

PRESSURE MOVES (use when they stall)

- _____
- _____

SCENES I CAN CUT IF IT DRAGS: _____

TONIGHT'S CLIFFHANGER (decide the ending beat): _____

Your game will flow and still belong to the players. Next you'll handle the moments the trouble is not in the story but at the table itself.

Part IV

Keep It Going

Chapter 10: When Things Go Wrong at the Table

Not every problem is in the story. Some are in the room. One player argues every ruling. Another checks their phone through the whole session. Two of them keep talking over the quiet one, who has not spoken in an hour. These are the problems no rulebook covers, and they are the ones most likely to end a campaign, because a bad rules call is forgotten by next week and a bad table feeling is not.

The good news is that table problems respond to the same tools as story problems: name the thing, address it early, and keep it kind. You are not a boss and your players are not staff. You are the person who volunteered to run the game, which gives you the right to protect it. Here are the situations you will meet, and what to do.

The rules lawyer

The player who knows the rules better than you and says so is usually not trying to undermine you. They love the game and want it played right. Use that. Make them an ally: "You know this better than me. Keep the real rule in your back pocket, and if I miss one, flag it after the scene." You gave their knowledge a job and a time, which is all most rules lawyers want. If one keeps stopping play to argue, hold the line you learned in Chapter 4: the ruling stands for this roll, the real rule starts next time, and we move on now.

The disengaged player

Before you blame the player scrolling their phone, ask why. Often they are bored because the spotlight has not touched them in an hour. The fix is on your side of the screen: turn to them by name and hand them a

moment. "The guard is blocking the door and looking right at you. What do you do?" A direct question with their name on it pulls almost anyone back. If it keeps happening across sessions, ask them privately what they want more of. Some players want combat, some want intrigue, and a quiet one is often a player in the wrong kind of scene, not a player who stopped caring.

The spotlight hog and the quiet one

These two problems are the same problem, and you solve them together. One or two loud players fill every scene while the quiet ones fade. Do not scold the loud ones. Redirect. Make a habit of going around the table by name, especially to the players who have not spoken. "Before you answer, Kesh, what's your character doing while this happens?" Spread the spotlight on purpose and the loud players still get their fun while the quiet ones get a way in. Balance is your job, and it is done with small nudges every scene, not one big correction.

Real conflict between players

Sometimes it is not a quirk, it is a clash: two players who want opposite games, or a personal friction that spills onto the table. Do not try to solve this mid-session in front of everyone. Pause the game if you must, then take it to a private conversation after. Name what you saw without taking a side, and ask what would make the game better for them. Most table conflict shrinks fast once someone with authority says out loud that they noticed and they care.

At a real table

Two sessions in, Jonah notices Priya has not spoken in forty minutes while two louder players run every scene. He does not scold anyone. He starts going around the table by name. "Before the guard answers, Priya, what's your character watching for?" She lights up and spots the ambush the loud players walked past. Later, privately, Jonah asks a checked-out player what they want more of. "Honestly, more fighting." The next session opens with a brawl in the first ten minutes, and the player is

back. Both problems fixed with small nudges, no confrontation.

At the table: the strongest tool you have is a check-in. Every few sessions, spend two minutes asking "what do you want more of, and less of?" It surfaces small frustrations before they grow into someone quietly quitting, and it tells the group you are running the game for them, not at them.

Handle it with the sheet

The flowchart below is your calm-in-the-moment reference for the table problems that catch new DMs off guard. It is not something you fill before play. Keep it nearby for the first few sessions, glance at it when the room feels off, and address the problem the same night in the smallest way that works.

The Table Troubleshooting Flowchart

Keep nearby during play. Printable copy in the download pack (last page).

THE ROOM FEELS OFF. WHAT IS IT?

- Someone argues every ruling make them your rules-ally;
"the ruling stands, real rule next time"
- Someone's checked out say their name, hand them a scene;
ask privately what they want more of
- One player fills every scene go around the table by name each scene
- A player has gone quiet give them a direct, low-stakes moment
- Two players are clashing pause; take it private after; name it,
don't take a side

EVERY FEW SESSIONS:

Ask the table: "More of what? Less of what?"

You can now protect the game as well as run it. Next you'll turn one good night into something that lasts: a campaign.

Chapter 11: From One Session to a Campaign

You ran the first session. The table laughed, someone almost died, and as everyone packed up a player asked the best question a DM can hear: "So when's next time?" Now you have a new job, and it is easier than the first one. A campaign is not eleven times the work of a session. It is one session, then another, connected by a thin thread you tend between games. This chapter shows you how to tend it without drowning in prep.

The mistake that ends first campaigns is not too little planning. It is too much. New DMs try to map a year of story, the players ignore the plan in week two, and the DM feels like a failure and quits. Do the opposite. Plan lightly, react fast, and let the campaign grow out of what the players actually do.

Close every session on purpose

The last five minutes of a session set up the next one, so do not let them dribble away. Do two things before everyone leaves. End on a hook, the cliffhanger you learned in Chapter 9, so the group leaves hungry. Then take one minute to jot what just happened: what the party did, what they said they would do next, and any thread you left dangling. That note is tomorrow's prep, half-written, while it is still fresh.

Prep the next session, not the whole story

Between games, you do the one-hour prep from Chapter 2, aimed at what the players pointed at when they left. You do not prepare the branches they might take. You prepare the branch they said they would take, and you keep the improv tables from Chapter 5 ready for the rest. This is the whole rhythm of running a campaign: a light note at the end

of each session, one hour of focused prep before the next, and trust in your tools for everything you did not see coming.

Let the thread thicken slowly

A campaign gains depth by remembering, not by planning. The bandit the players spared in session two comes back grateful in session six. The offhand rumor about the lake becomes the next arc because the players kept poking at it. Your job between sessions is to look at your notes and ask one question: what did the players care about, and how does the world respond? Follow their attention and the campaign writes itself, one callback at a time. The villain you planned matters less than the enemy they made by accident.

Grow as a DM the same way

You will get better session by session, and the fastest way is to keep the same short note for yourself that you keep for the story. After each game, write one thing that worked and one thing you would change. Not a review, one line each. Over ten sessions those lines become your own style guide, earned at the table instead of read in a book. The confident DM you want to be is only you, a dozen sessions from now, having paid attention.

At a real table

After session one, Bel spends sixty seconds on a recap: the party freed a prisoner, promised to warn the next village, and left a bandit alive. Before the next game she runs the one-hour prep on the village they are heading to, and she rewards their mercy: the spared bandit turns up as a nervous informant. Ten sessions later, her "plan" is mostly callbacks to things the players did, stitched together one recap at a time. She never mapped a year of story. She only kept the note, and the campaign grew itself.

***At the table:** keep a running "party legend" list where everyone can see it: names they've met, places they've been, promises they've made. It saves you from contradicting yourself, and it shows the players their choices are*

remembered, which is the feeling that turns a game group into a campaign.

Carry it forward with two sheets

The templates below close the loop. The recap sheet captures a session in one minute while it is fresh. The next-session sheet turns that recap into your one-hour prep. Run this loop and a campaign stops being a mountain and becomes what it should be: the next good night, and then the one after that.

The Session Recap and Next-Session Prep Sheets

One pair per session. Printable copies in the download pack (last page).

SESSION RECAP (fill in one minute, right after playing)

Session #: ____ Date: ____
What the party did: _____
What they said they'll do next: _____
Threads left dangling: _____
New names/places/promises to remember: _____

NEXT-SESSION PREP (fill before you play again)

Their stated next step points to: _____
-> run the 1-Hour Prep Worksheet (Chapter 2) on THAT
One callback to reward their past choices: _____
One thread to nudge if they stall: _____

That is the core job, start to finish. You can prep a session in an hour, run the table with confidence, and turn one night into a campaign. The two chapters that follow are extras for when you are ready: running your game online, and handing out treasure without breaking it. After that, the appendices hand you two finished adventures and the tables to build your own. Next you'll take the whole system online.

Extras

When You're Ready for More

Chapter 12: Running the Game Online

Your table might not be a table. More first games happen over video and a virtual tabletop now than around anyone's kitchen, and the online room has its own traps. The good news is that every method in this book still works. You still prep in an hour, still make rulings, still improvise with the tables. What changes is the plumbing, and a few small habits keep the plumbing from eating your session.

This chapter is short on purpose. You do not need a streaming studio to run a good online game. You need clear sound, a shared way to see the action, and a handful of moves that replace the things a physical table gives you for free.

Sound beats everything else

In person, people read each other without trying. Online, all of that collapses into audio, so sound is the one thing worth getting right. Ask everyone to use headphones, which kills the echo that makes a group unlistenable. A cheap wired headset beats a laptop microphone in a hard room. Before you start, do one round of "say something" so you catch the player whose mic is dead before they miss the first scene. Everything else you can improvise. Bad audio you cannot.

Give them one thing to look at

An online group drifts when there is nothing to share their eyes on. You do not need a gridded battle map with animated torches. You need one shared screen: a simple map, a picture of the room, even a document with the scene written on it. When combat starts, something as plain as tokens on a grid keeps everyone clear on who is where. Pick one tool and learn the three buttons you use. The fanciest virtual tabletop run by a

DM who is fighting the software is worse than a shared image and theater of the mind.

Hand out the spotlight on purpose

The online room hides your quiet players even more than a real one does. Nobody leans in, nobody catches an eye. So you do the work the table used to do. Go around by name every scene, the same habit from Chapter 10, and it matters twice as much here. Watch for the player who starts a sentence and gets talked over, and come back to them: "Kesh, you were about to say something." Online, that small rescue is often the difference between a player who stays and one who quietly stops showing up.

Fight the second screen

Every player online is one click from a browser, a chat, a game. You will not win that war by policing it. You win it by keeping scenes moving and stakes clear, so there is no dead air to fill with a phone. End scenes a beat early. Cut to the next choice. Ask direct questions that need an answer now. A tight online session holds attention that a slow one loses, and the pacing tools from Chapter 9 are your best defense against the second screen.

At the table: post the initiative order where everyone can see it and say "you're up, and Sela is on deck." Naming who is next keeps players present, because they know their moment is coming and they do not want to be caught scrolling when it arrives.

At a real table

Dana runs her whole campaign over video for friends in three cities. Her prep is the same one-hour system. Her only extra step is a two-minute sound check at the top and a single shared map tab she updates by hand. When a fight breaks out she drops tokens on a grid and narrates the rest. Her players forget they are not in the same room, because she spends her attention on the spotlight and the pacing, not on software. The tools carried over. She only changed the plumbing.

Set up your virtual table

The checklist below is your pre-game plumbing pass. Run it once before your first online session and once more whenever a new player joins. It takes five minutes and saves the half-hour of "can you hear me now" that kills an online group's energy.

The Virtual Table Checklist

Run before an online session. Printable copy in the download pack (last page).

BEFORE THE SESSION

- ☐ Everyone on headphones
- ☐ One-round sound check ("say something")
- ☐ Shared screen ready: map / image / scene doc
- ☐ Dice: physical on camera, or one agreed roller
- ☐ A backup text chat, in case a mic dies

DURING

- ☐ Initiative order posted where all can see
- ☐ "You're up, ___ on deck" each turn
- ☐ Go around by name each scene
- ☐ Rescue the talked-over player

IF THE TECH BREAKS

- Fall back to theater of the mind and keep going.
- Never stop the story to fix software mid-scene.

Online or in person, the game is the same. Next you'll hand out treasure without wrecking the balance you worked to build.

Chapter 13: Treasure and Magic Items Without Breaking the Game

Handing out treasure feels like it should be the easy, fun part, and then a new DM gives a level-one party a flaming sword and spends the next year watching every fight end in one round. Reward is a lever, the same as an encounter is a lever, and it is as easy to push too hard. This chapter keeps your generosity from wrecking the balance you built in Chapter 7, while still letting the players feel rich.

The trick is simple. Give money and useful gear freely. Give raw power slowly and on purpose. A party can never have too many interesting objects. It can easily have too many ways to kill things without trying.

Coins are the safe reward

Money is the reward you can hand out with both hands. It buys gear, pays for rooms and bribes, and funds the next adventure, and none of it warps a fight. When you are not sure how much to give, give coin and mundane gear: a better shield, a healer's kit, a horse, a map. The players feel the win, the math of your encounters does not move, and they get to make choices about what to buy, which is its own kind of fun.

Tie coin to the fiction so it never feels like a slot machine. The bandit captain has the village's stolen tax box. The dead merchant's ring is worth a month's wages. Rewards that come from the story land harder than a pile of gold that appears because the players won.

Magic items are power, so meter them

A magic item changes what a character can do, and that is why they are precious and why they are dangerous in a new DM's hands. Two rules keep them safe. Give one real combat-boosting item per character across

the early levels, not per session. And prefer items that open new options over items that add raw damage. A rope that ties itself, boots that walk on water, a cloak that hides a face: these create stories and solve problems without turning every fight into a slaughter. Save the flaming sword for a milestone, and it will feel earned instead of routine.

When a player does get a powerful item, let the world notice. The sword that cuts through stone is the kind of thing other people want. Power that draws attention stays exciting, because owning it costs something. An item nobody reacts to is only a bigger number.

Cursed and quirky, used lightly

A little unpredictability makes treasure memorable, but a mean surprise sours a table fast. Keep quirks flavorful, not punishing. A helm that hums when danger is near and also gives its wearer strange dreams is fun. A helm that secretly halves the wearer's healing is a trap that teaches players never to touch your treasure again. When in doubt, make the downside a story hook, not a stat penalty.

***At the table:** when you hand over a magic item, describe what it feels like, not what it does. "The ring is warm, and warmer when you lie" invites the player to discover its power in play, which is far more memorable than reading them a rules block across the table.*

At a real table

Omar wants to reward his level-two party after a hard dungeon. His instinct is a magic weapon for everyone. Instead he gives them the villain's coin box, a deed to the ruined mill, and one magic item for the whole party to argue over: a lantern that reveals hidden doors. The coin lets them re-equip, the deed becomes a base and a plot hook, and the lantern sends them looking for secret passages for months. He gave them a great haul and did not touch the balance of a single future fight.

A starter magic-item shelf

The table below is fifteen low-risk magic items built to delight without breaking a game. Every one opens options more than it adds damage, so you can hand them out early without fear. Roll, or pick the one that fits the story.

Starter Magic Items (d20, reroll 16-20 or pick)

Printable copy in the download pack (last page).

- 1 Ring of Warning: warms when danger is within sight
- 2 Everfull Waterskin: makes a day's clean water each dawn
- 3 Whispering Stone: two holders can speak a sentence once a day, any distance
- 4 Climbing Gloves: grip any surface for a short climb
- 5 Mapmaker's Quill: draws the room you stand in, once per day
- 6 Mask of the Seen: look like anyone you have met, for a minute
- 7 Silent Boots: leave no sound and no tracks
- 8 Lantern of Doors: reveals hidden openings within its light
- 9 Menders' Thread: repairs one broken object a day
- 10 Featherfall Cloak: a slow, safe fall, once per day
- 11 Beast-Tongue Charm: understand one animal for a scene
- 12 Coin of Return: thrown, it flies back to your hand
- 13 Kettle of Plenty: cooks a warm meal for six from scraps
- 14 Truth Candle: while it burns, lies are hard to speak nearby
- 15 Keyworm: reshapes to fit one lock, then crumbles
- 16 (pick from above, or invent one that opens an option)
- 17 (as 16)
- 18 (as 16)
- 19 (as 16)
- 20 (as 16)

Your players can grow rich and equipped without ever outrunning your fights. Next, in the appendices, you have two complete adventures, a starter bestiary, and tables to keep the game fed for a long time.

Appendices

Adventures, Monsters, and Tables

Appendix: The Drowned Bell (A Complete First Adventure)

You have the methods. Here is a whole first session built with them, ready to run. Every template in this book is filled in below, so you can read it as a finished adventure and as a worked example at the same time. Change any name that does not fit your table. Cross out anything you do not use. It is built for four new players at level one and runs in a single evening of about three hours.

Read it once, keep this appendix open beside your screen, and go.

The pitch, in three sentences

The village of Hollowmere sits on the edge of a flooded quarry. For a hundred years a bell has hung in the old chapel tower at the water's bottom, silent. Three nights ago it began to ring on its own, and every night since, someone in the village has walked into the water in their sleep and not come back.

That is the whole hook. A ringing bell, sleepwalkers drowning, a village that is scared. The players are strangers passing through who are asked, or paid, to make it stop.

The opening scene (do not skip this)

Start in the flooded street at dusk, not the tavern. The party arrives as villagers are tying a rope around a sleepwalking woman before she reaches the water. She is calm, eyes open, humming a tune in time with a bell only she can hear. A man begs the party for help. The trouble is already happening on the first line. That is your start.

The First-Session Checklist, filled in

1 - THE OPENING SCENE

Where they start: the flooded main street of Hollowmere at dusk
The trouble already happening: villagers restraining a sleepwalker
First line I say: "She's humming. Her feet are already in the water."

2 - TONIGHT'S GOAL

One thing they could do: find why the bell rings and silence it

3 - THREE NPCs

Elder Maren – the reeve, wants the deaths hidden to avoid panic
Toma – a boy whose sister already drowned, wants revenge, knows the water
Sister Vey – a hedge-priest, wants the chapel's sin finally confessed

4 - ONE DANGER

What can go wrong: the drowned dead rise when the bell rings
Where/when it hits: at the bottom of the quarry, near the tower

5 - MY SAFETY LINE

If I freeze, I ask: "What does your character do?"

The village and its people

Hollowmere is thirty houses, a chapel, and a quarry that flooded a lifetime ago. The people are tired and frightened, and each of the three named NPCs holds one of the three clues the party needs. Play them with the one-line cards below.

NPC CARD – Elder Maren

Where met: the main street, organizing the rope
WANT: keep the deaths quiet so the village does not empty out
TRAIT: answers every question with a question
VOICE: clipped, official
OPINION OF PARTY: distrusts (outsiders mean gossip)
SECRET/HOOK: knows the drowned all shared one ancestor

NPC CARD – Toma

Where met: at the water's edge, throwing stones at the quarry
WANT: someone to blame, and to save the next sleeper
TRAIT: will not look at the water while he talks about it
VOICE: fast, angry, young
HOOK: saw his sister walk in; she was humming the bell's tune

NPC CARD – Sister Vey

Where met: the chapel, praying over a list of names
WANT: the village to finally admit what happened here
TRAIT: touches the old bell-rope burn scar on her palm
VOICE: slow, gentle, certain
HOOK: knows a bell-ringer was sealed in the tower alive, long ago

The mystery and the three ways in

The key fact the players must reach is simple: a hundred years ago the village sealed a plague-sick bell-ringer inside the tower to keep the sickness out, and let the quarry flood over him. His anger is what rings the bell and calls the sleepers to join him. The players do not need to guess this. Three separate clues each point at it, and finding any one is enough.

ADVENTURE ONE-PAGE – The Drowned Bell

THE PARTY'S GOAL: stop the bell and the drownings

THREE-CLUE RULE (key fact: a ringing bell = a man sealed to drown, calling company)

Clue path 1: Maren admits the drowned all share one ancestor, the family that sealed the tower

Clue path 2: Toma repeats the tune his sister hummed; Vey knows it as the old ringer's hymn

Clue path 3: church records in the chapel name a ringer "given to the water" in the plague year

THE CLOCK (why idling costs them)

The bell rings again at midnight. Each night, one more villager walks in. Tonight it will be Toma unless they act.

PRESSURE MOVES (use if they stall)

- The bell begins to ring early; a sleeper they know starts humming
- Maren tries to send them away to protect the village's name

CLIFFHANGER IF YOU SPLIT IT OVER TWO NIGHTS:

the water in the quarry begins, slowly, to lower on its own

Into the water: the Drowned Bell tower

When the party goes down into the flooded quarry (a diving charm, a held breath and a Constitution check, or "the water pulls back at midnight and a stair appears," your call), they enter the tower as a five-room crawl.

5-ROOM DUNGEON – The Drowned Bell

THEME: a flooded chapel tower

WHY THE PARTY COMES HERE: to reach and silence the bell

1 - ENTRANCE + GUARDIAN

The tower door, held shut by the weight of a hundred years of silt. Cost to enter: a Strength check, or clear the silt while something watches from the dark water.

2 - PUZZLE / ROLEPLAY CHALLENGE

A ring of drowned villagers, calm and humming, block the stair. They will not fight. They will only move if a living person hums the ringer's hymn back to them (a clue from Toma or Vey), acknowledging him.

3 - THE SETBACK

The bell rings. The recently drowned rise as grasping dead (see encounter below). The stair begins to flood again; the party has a few rounds.

4 - THE CLIMAX

The bell-chamber. The ringer's bound spirit hangs in the water, ringing the bell with no hands. He wants one thing: to be heard, and freed, or destroyed.

5 - REWARD + TWIST

Silence the bell and the water stills. The reward is the village's thanks and the ringer's old silver seal. The twist: the seal bears Maren's family crest. Her ancestors sealed him. She knew.

The one fight, built to the budget

The adventure needs only one real fight, at the setback. Keep it fair for level-one newcomers with the budget below.

ENCOUNTER BALANCE – The Rising Drowned

PARTY: 4 at level 1

BUDGET: standard = 4 threat points

SPEND IT:

Drowned villager (weak, grasping) x4	 ~2 pts	"zombie-lite"
Bell-called revenant (mid threat) x1	 ~2 pts	the loudest sleeper
Total ≈ 4 pts (matches budget)		

DANGER DIAL (turned):

Terrain: rising water, difficult to move each round

Reinforcements: one more drowned rises each round the bell still rings

The way out: silence the bell and every drowned goes still at once

WHAT THEY GET FOR WINNING: the water stills, the village is saved, the seal

The design teaches the players the win condition through the fight: attacking the dead is slow and endless, but the bell is the source. A smart party stops fighting and goes for the bell. Reward that. If they do not see it, have a drowned villager, in the ringer's voice, whisper "make it stop" and glance at the bell.

How it ends, and where it goes next

If the party frees or destroys the ringer, the bell falls silent and the quarry stills. Give them the village's real gratitude, a warm meal, and the silver seal. Then let the twist land in its own time: the seal is Maren's family crest, and she has known the truth all along. That is your hook into session two, already built by the ending of session one, exactly as Chapter 11 promised. The players will want to know what else the village buried, and you will run the one-hour prep on wherever they decide to look.

You have run a whole adventure out of five filled-in templates. That is the entire method of this book, start to finish. Now go build your own.

Appendix: The Starter Bestiary

You do not need the full monster manual to run your first months of games. You need a short, trustworthy list you can drop into the encounter budget from Chapter 7 without flipping pages. Here it is. Every monster below is written the way a new DM actually uses one at the table: what it is worth in threat points, the three numbers you call for most, and one line on how it fights so it does not play like every other creature.

How to read a stat line

Each entry gives you five things and nothing you will not use in the first hour.

Threat is the point value from Chapter 7. One point is roughly a fair share of a standard fight for one player at the monster's tier. HP is how much damage it takes to drop. AC (armor class) is the number a player must meet or beat to hit it. Attack is the bonus you add to a d20 when it swings, and the damage it deals on a hit. Move is the one tactic that makes it feel like itself.

When you build a fight, add up threat to match your budget, then read the Move line so the monsters do not all stand still and trade blows. That one line is the difference between a memorable fight and a math problem.

Tier 1: for level 1 to 2 parties

NAME	THREAT	HP	AC	ATTACK	MOVE
Rat swarm	0.5	14	12	+3, 4 dmg	surrounds; hard to hit with one blow
Bandit	0.5	11	12	+3, 5 dmg	flees when it is losing
Wolf	0.5	11	13	+4, 6 dmg	knocks prone; hunts in a pack
Skeleton	0.5	13	13	+4, 5 dmg	ignores pain; keeps coming
Giant rat	0.25	7	12	+4, 4 dmg	swarms a downed target
Kobold	0.25	5	12	+4, 4 dmg	only brave in numbers
Zombie	0.5	22	8	+3, 6 dmg	slow, refuses to fall
Bandit captain	2	30	15	+5, 8 dmg (x2)	rallies nearby bandits
Giant spider	1	26	14	+5, 7 dmg	webs a target in place
Cultist	0.5	9	12	+3, 4 dmg	fights harder near its shrine

Tier 2: for level 3 to 5 parties

NAME	THREAT	HP	AC	ATTACK	MOVE
Ogre	2	59	11	+6, 13 dmg	one huge hit; slow to turn
Dire wolf	1	37	14	+5, 10 dmg	knocks prone, pack tactics
Bugbear	1	27	16	+4, 11 dmg	hits hardest on the first surprise blow
Ghoul	1	22	12	+4, 7 dmg	paralyzes on a failed save
Bandit sorcerer	2	27	12	+5, spell 8 dmg	hits a cluster; fragile up close
Animated armor	1	33	18	+4, 6 dmg (x2)	hard to hit; no mind to fool
Owlbear	3	59	13	+7, 14 dmg	grabs and does not let go
Will-o-wisp	2	22	19	+4, 9 dmg	floats, lures into danger
Priest (evil)	2	27	13	+5, heals allies	keeps the fight going
Giant boar	1	42	11	+5, 10 dmg	charges, knocks prone

Tier 3: single bosses for a whole party

These are built to fight a party of four alone, or with a few minions from the tiers above. A boss should get more than one action a round so it does not lose to four attackers before it acts. Give it the Legendary line below: an extra move on other players' turns.

NAME	THREAT	HP	AC	ATTACK	MOVE + LEGENDARY
Ogre chieftain	4	93	13	+7, 14 dmg (x2)	Legendary: after a hit, shove a foe back
Young wyvern	5	110	14	+7, 11 + poison	Legendary: dives from the air next turn
Cult high priest	4	75	15	+6, spell 18 dmg	Legendary: curse a foe (disadvantage)
Troll	5	84	15	+7, 12 dmg (x2)	regenerates unless burned; extra bite
Bandit warlord	4	90	17	+7, 10 dmg (x2)	Legendary: command an ally to strike
Barrow wraith	5	67	13	+6, 13 necrotic	Legendary: drain, heal for half dealt

Run a boss by giving it one normal turn plus one Legendary move on someone else's turn. That rhythm keeps the biggest fight in the adventure from ending before it begins, and it is the whole secret to a climax that feels dangerous.

A quick word on traps

Traps are monsters that do not move. Give each one a way to spot it (a check, or a clue you narrate), a way to beat it (a check, or a clever action), and a cost for failing (damage, an alarm, a separation). If a trap can only be found by one lucky roll and kills on a failure, it is not a challenge, it is a coin flip. Telegraph the danger, offer more than one

way past, and let the players feel clever for beating it.

Reskin, do not rebuild

The fastest bestiary trick is paint. The wolf, the dire wolf, and the giant boar are all "a fast thing that knocks you down," and you can call them wolves in a forest, hounds in a crypt, or a stampede on the road without changing a number. When you need a monster you do not have, find the closest line above, keep the numbers, and change the name and the one Move detail. Your players meet a fresh creature. You did no extra work.

A note on death

New DMs fear killing a character to a bad roll, and they should. Two habits keep the game fair. First, telegraph deadly threats: describe the ogre's reach and the drop behind the party before the swing, so choices are informed. Second, let most defeated foes take prisoners, demand surrender, or flee, so a lost fight is a setback and not a funeral. Save lethal, no-mercy combat for a moment you built toward, and it will hit far harder for being rare.

Appendix: Rolls and Seeds

This appendix is fuel. When you need a name, a rumor, a reward, or a whole next adventure and you need it now, roll here. Everything is built to be used live, mid-session, without breaking the flow. Tear these pages out or copy them from the download pack and keep them under your screen.

d100 names, grab and go

Roll d100, or read down until one fits. Cross off the ones you use so a name never repeats in the same town.

1 Bren	21 Sela	41 Halla	61 Ysolde	81 Corvin
2 Kesh	22 Doran	42 Nix	62 Aurelian	82 Wren
3 Mira	23 Toma	43 Grud	63 Vespera	83 Dalia
4 Alric	24 Petra	44 Sump	64 Castellan	84 Osríc
5 Nessa	25 Joss	45 Vane	65 Ilse	85 Perrin
6 Garrick	26 Fenn	46 Bricktop	66 Roran	86 Odette
7 Lyra	27 Hale	47 Mudge	67 Selene	87 Bardan
8 Cael	28 Vira	48 Skarn	68 Tobias	88 Ren
9 Marta	29 Ovid	49 Grix	69 Amaris	89 Halric
10 Bo	30 Della	50 Thrun	70 Emeric	90 Sable
11 Rook	31 Ansel	51 Pia	71 Lucan	91 Noor
12 Edda	32 Wystan	52 Karn	72 Orla	92 Dain
13 Fable	33 Rhea	53 Bael	73 Cyrus	93 Merric
14 Sten	34 Colm	54 Yorick	74 Nadia	94 Piper
15 Ivo	35 Tansy	55 Dregg	75 Alban	95 Sorrel
16 Wexley	36 Hob	56 Mór	76 Cressa	96 Talon
17 Runa	37 Ede	57 Vosk	77 Emil	97 Bex
18 Corthan	38 Silas	58 Ravel	78 Isolde	98 Wm. "Ledger"
19 Prue	39 Nyla	59 Drusa	79 Fenwick	99 Ada
20 Merrow	40 Kade	60 Halloran	80 Sighard	100 Old Bram

d20 rumors for any tavern

Roll two or three when the party listens around a town. Some are true, some are bent, and that mix is what makes a place feel alive.

- 1 A merchant went out on the old road and only his cart came back.
- 2 The miller pays too well for grain nobody can eat.
- 3 Lights move in the burned watchtower on moonless nights.
- 4 The priest has not opened the chapel crypt in a year.
- 5 A child in the next village can name the day a stranger will die.
- 6 The lord's new advisor casts no reflection, they say.
- 7 Wolves this winter hunt in a line, like soldiers.
- 8 Someone is buying old maps of the drowned quarter, no questions.
- 9 The well went sweet the same week the healer went missing.
- 10 A gambler won three nights straight, then vanished owing nothing.
- 11 The bridge toll doubled and the toll-keeper is new and pale.
- 12 Farmers found their scarecrows moved closer to the house each dawn.
- 13 The mine reopened, but no ore has come out and no miner has come up.
- 14 A traveling troupe left one wagon behind, locked, and did not return.
- 15 The baker's bread keeps the sick alive longer than it should.
- 16 Two moons were seen last week. Nobody agrees which night.
- 17 The graves on the hill face the wrong way now.
- 18 A debt-collector arrived asking for a family that died out generations ago.
- 19 The river brought down a door, carved, from no house anyone knows.
- 20 Everyone in the almshouse had the same dream, and drew the same tower.

d20 rewards beyond coins

Treasure the players will remember does something or points somewhere. Roll when they win.

- 1 A ring that warms when a lie is spoken nearby.
- 2 A map with one room marked that is not on any other map.
- 3 A favor owed by someone powerful, in writing, signed.
- 4 A key with no lock yet found, humming faintly.
- 5 A vial that turns any water to clean drinking water, once a day.
- 6 A cloak that muffles sound around its wearer.
- 7 A ledger of debts, one of which is the villain's.
- 8 A whistle only certain animals answer.
- 9 A coin that always lands on the same face.
- 10 A letter of introduction to a guild or a court.
- 11 A lantern that burns with no fuel but only shows the truth.
- 12 A dagger that never needs sharpening and never draws blood it should not.
- 13 A deed to a ruined property with a secret still inside.
- 14 A songbook whose last page is torn out and coveted.
- 15 A pair of boots that leave no tracks.
- 16 A jar of soil that keeps one plant alive anywhere.
- 17 A mask that lets the wearer pass for someone they have seen.
- 18 A compass that points at what the holder most fears.
- 19 A seal that opens one specific door, somewhere.
- 20 A name. Only a name, whispered by the dying, that matters later.

Six adventure seeds, ready to grow

Each seed is a whole adventure in the shape from Chapter 9: a goal, a three-clue path, and a clock. Pick one, fill the blanks with your table's names, and run the one-hour prep on it. Together with the starter adventure, these give you a season of play.

SEED 1 – The Salt in the Well

Goal: find why the town's water is poisoning people

Clues: a dead fox upstream - a bought-off inspector - a rival town's map

Clock: the harvest festival is in three days and the whole town will drink

SEED 2 – The Debt of Ash

Goal: protect a family from a collector who is not human

Clues: a contract signed in a dead grandparent's hand - a witness who fled -
a symbol burned in the barn

Clock: the collector returns at the next new moon to take "what is owed"

SEED 3 – The Quiet Mine

Goal: learn why the reopened mine sends no one back up

Clues: a miner's boot at the entrance - a cut rope - a fresh wall where none belongs

Clock: the mine owner hires more workers tomorrow, sending them to their deaths

SEED 4 – The Wrong Heir

Goal: settle who truly inherits a manor before a feud turns to blood

Clues: a forged will - a servant who was there - a portrait painted over

Clock: the reading of the will is at dusk, and armed men are already gathering

SEED 5 – The Troupe's Last Wagon

Goal: open the locked wagon a vanished troupe left behind

Clues: a playbill for a show that never happened - a key swallowed by a fish -
a child who remembers the songs

Clock: whatever is inside is waking, and it wants an audience

SEED 6 – The Turned Graves

Goal: stop the dead on the hill from rising, now facing the town

Clues: a grave-digger's confession - a stone with a scratched-out name -
a priest who left in a hurry

Clock: the graves turn a little more each night; on the seventh they open

d20 traps and hazards

Every trap here has a tell, a beat, and a cost, the way Chapter 7 and the bestiary ask. Narrate the tell before the players trigger it.

- 1 A pressure plate; tell: worn floor stones; cost: darts from the walls
- 2 A pit under a rug; tell: the rug is too clean; cost: a fall and a sprain
- 3 A gas vent; tell: a faint sweet smell; cost: sleep on a failed save
- 4 A collapsing stair; tell: cracked mortar; cost: a drop and separation
- 5 A swinging blade; tell: a groove worn in the wall; cost: a heavy cut
- 6 A rising water room; tell: damp waterline; cost: a race against drowning
- 7 A rune-warded door; tell: faint glowing marks; cost: a burst of fire
- 8 A net trap; tell: rope dust from above; cost: caught and hauled up
- 9 A false floor over spikes; tell: a hollow sound; cost: a nasty fall
- 10 A poisoned lock; tell: a green stain; cost: poison on a failed save
- 11 A rolling weight; tell: a slot in the ceiling; cost: outrun it or be hit
- 12 A shrieking ward; tell: a thin wire; cost: it summons the guards
- 13 A crushing wall; tell: fresh scrape marks; cost: escape before it closes
- 14 A grasping vine; tell: too-green growth; cost: held until it is cut
- 15 A mirror that swaps a hand's contents; tell: a cold shimmer; cost: theft
- 16 A bridge that tilts; tell: it is on a pivot; cost: a slide into the dark
- 17 A hall of darts and a safe path; tell: a scuffed safe line; cost: many small cuts
- 18 A frost sigil; tell: rime on the floor; cost: cold and slowed movement
- 19 A memory ward; tell: a humming stone; cost: forget the last minute
- 20 A guardian statue; tell: no dust on its base; cost: it wakes and strikes

d20 town and tavern names

Roll one of each when the party arrives somewhere you did not name.

TOWNS: 1 Ardwick 2 Hollowmere 3 Greypool 4 Thornfield 5 Saltcombe
 6 Dunmoor 7 Fenwick 8 Ashford 9 Millbrook 10 Coldharbor
 11 Ravenscross 12 Oldbridge 13 Marsh End 14 Highcairn
 15 Blackmoss 16 Elderton 17 Stonewell 18 Redmarch
 19 Winterbourne 20 Gallowsfield

TAVERNS: 1 The Broken Wheel 2 The Salted Crow 3 The Last Lantern
 4 The Drowned Rat 5 The Gilded Sow 6 The Quiet Man
 7 The Cracked Bell 8 The Green Door 9 The Wayward Son
 10 The Iron Kettle 11 The Sleeping Giant 12 The Fox and Fiddle
 13 The Copper Cup 14 The Rusty Anchor 15 The Hunter's Rest
 16 The Third Moon 17 The Pilgrim's Foot 18 The Bent Nail
 19 The Widow's Table 20 The Long Winter

d20 what the villain does while the party dawdles

When the players take their time, the world does not. Roll to advance the enemy's plan and turn idleness into pressure.

- 1 Recruits more followers from the desperate
- 2 Silences a witness the party needed
- 3 Moves the ritual up a day
- 4 Buys off a guard or an official
- 5 Sends a scout to watch the party
- 6 Frames the party for a crime
- 7 Takes a hostage the party cares about
- 8 Fortifies the lair with new traps
- 9 Spreads a rumor that ruins the party's welcome
- 10 Completes one step of the larger plan
- 11 Poisons a well or a food store
- 12 Strikes a deal with a rival of the party
- 13 Relocates the treasure the party is after
- 14 Sends assassins in the night
- 15 Wins over a town leader to their side
- 16 Destroys the evidence the party sought
- 17 Sacrifices a follower to gain power
- 18 Sets a trap where the party will go next
- 19 Escalates: an innocent dies to prove they are serious
- 20 Vanishes, leaving the party chasing a cold trail

Between two full adventures, six seeds, and these tables, you will not run dry for a long time. Roll, fill, prep, and play. The table is waiting.

Appendix: The Hunger Under the Hill (A Second Adventure)

Here is a second complete adventure, ready to run, pitched a little higher than the first. The Drowned Bell suits a brand-new group at level one. The Hunger Under the Hill fits a party of four at level two or three, once everyone has a session or two of confidence. Like the first, every template is filled in below, so you can run it tonight or read it as a worked example of the whole method at a slightly larger scale.

The pitch, in three sentences

The village of Ardwick is starving through a hard winter, and a week ago the children began to sneak away toward the old barrow hill at the edge of the fields. Those who follow them find nothing but frost and a door in the earth that was not there before. Something under the hill is promising the children a feast, and every night it takes a few more.

The players arrive hungry and cold to a village that has stopped hoping. Whether they came for shelter, for pay, or by accident, Ardwick will beg them to bring the children back.

The opening scene

Start at the barrow door at dusk, not in the village square. The party crests the hill to find three children walking calmly toward a black opening in the frozen earth, and a mother screaming behind a frost that will not let her follow. One child turns, smiles, and says, "There is bread inside. Warm bread." Then he steps into the dark. The trouble is already underway. That is your first line.

The First-Session Checklist, filled in

1 - THE OPENING SCENE

Where they start: the barrow hill at dusk, children walking to the door
The trouble already happening: three children entering the earth
First line I say: "He smiles and says: there is bread inside. Warm bread."

2 - TONIGHT'S GOAL

One thing they could do: enter the barrow and bring the children back

3 - THREE NPCs

Reeve Alder – leads Ardwick, wants the children back and the truth buried
Old Hesper – a starving hermit, wants to confess what the village fed the hill before
The Provider – the thing under the hill, wants to be fed, and adored

4 - ONE DANGER

What can go wrong: the barrow's servants take a character who eats its food
Where/when it hits: the feast-hall at the heart of the barrow

5 - MY SAFETY LINE

If I freeze, I ask: "What does your character do?"

Ardwick and its people

Ardwick is a farming village that has run out of food and out of luck.

Fear has made its people quiet and its reeve secretive, because the village has a debt to the hill that no one wants spoken. Each named NPC carries one clue.

NPC CARD – Reeve Alder

Where met: at the barrow, holding back the grieving parents
WANT: the children back, and the old bargain kept secret
TRAIT: will not say the word "barrow," calls it "the hill"
VOICE: careful, official, tired
OPINION OF PARTY: wary; useful outsiders, and possible witnesses
SECRET: generations ago Ardwick fed the hill in lean years, and stopped

NPC CARD – Old Hesper

Where met: a frost-rimed hut past the last field
WANT: to unburden the truth before he starves
TRAIT: laughs at the wrong moments, has not eaten in days
VOICE: cracked, wandering, sudden
HOOK: remembers his own brother walking into the hill, decades ago

NPC CARD – The Provider

Where met: the feast-hall, at the barrow's heart
WANT: to be fed and worshipped as it once was
TRAIT: speaks in the voices of the children it has taken
VOICE: warm, generous, wrong
HOOK: it is bound to the hill and cannot leave, only lure

The mystery and the three ways in

The key fact the players must reach: the thing under the hill is an old bound spirit that Ardwick once fed in exchange for good harvests, and it is calling in a debt the village stopped paying. Its food is a trap. Any

living person who eats at its table becomes one of its servants, and the children are being fattened for exactly that. Three clues point here.

ADVENTURE ONE-PAGE – The Hunger Under the Hill

THE PARTY'S GOAL: bring the children out of the barrow alive

THREE-CLUE RULE (key fact: the hill's food binds the eater; the children are being fed)

Clue path 1: Hesper's confession about the old bargain and his lost brother

Clue path 2: a servant of the hill still wears a decades-old face, not a child's

Clue path 3: the feast is endless and the eaters never leave the table

THE CLOCK (why idling costs them)

Each night, the hill takes more. On the third night, the eldest child eats, and eating is the point of no easy return.

PRESSURE MOVES (use if they stall)

- A child they were told to protect slips out of the village toward the hill
- The Provider offers the party a warm meal, kindly, at the worst moment

CLIFFHANGER IF YOU SPLIT IT:

the party finds one rescued child humming, and asking, quietly, for bread

Into the earth: the barrow

The barrow is a five-room crawl, and it is warmer and stranger the deeper it goes, because the Provider dresses its trap as comfort.

5-ROOM DUNGEON – The Hunger Under the Hill

THEME: a false feast in a cold barrow

WHY THE PARTY COMES HERE: to find and free the children

1 - ENTRANCE + GUARDIAN

A door of frozen earth that only opens to the hungry. Cost to enter: admit aloud that you are hungry, or force it with a Strength check as the frost bites (cold damage on a failure).

2 - PUZZLE / ROLEPLAY CHALLENGE

A hall of tables piled with warm, perfect food and seated, silent eaters. The way through is to pass the feast without eating. Tempt the players. A character who eats is marked (disadvantage until they leave the hill).

3 - THE SETBACK

The eaters rise as servants of the hill and block the way back (see the encounter below). The children are close ahead, being led to the head table.

4 - THE CLIMAX

The feast-hall. The Provider, wearing the children's voices, offers the party a seat and a bargain: leave the children, and Ardwick will never hunger again.

5 - REWARD + TWIST

Refuse or break the Provider, and the food turns to frost and dust. The children wake, thin and frightened. The reward is their lives and Ardwick's thanks. The twist: the Provider's last words, in Reeve Alder's voice, say "you promised." Alder made a new bargain to save the harvest, and gave the hill the children to seal it.

The one fight, built to the budget

The barrow needs one real fight, at the setback, tuned for a level two or three party.

ENCOUNTER BALANCE – The Risen Feast

PARTY: 4 at level 2-3

BUDGET: standard = 4 threat points

SPEND IT:

Hill-servant (former villager, grasping) x4 ... ~2 pts "ghoul-lite, no bite save"
Feast-warden (mid threat, herds the party) x1 ... ~2 pts drags eaters toward the table
Total ≈ 4 pts (matches budget)

DANGER DIAL (turned):

Terrain: long feast-tables to climb over or shove enemies across
Reinforcements: a seated eater wakes each round the party lingers
The way out: reach the children, or break the feast, and the servants slow

WHAT THEY GET FOR WINNING: a clear path to the feast-hall and the climax

The fight teaches the lesson the adventure runs on: you cannot win by killing every servant, because the hill makes more. The way out is forward, to the children and the Provider, not backward through an endless feast. Reward the party that figures that out.

How it ends, and where it goes next

Break or refuse the Provider and the barrow dies around the party as they carry the children into the cold air. Give Ardwick its ragged, real gratitude. Then let the twist do its work: the Provider spoke in Reeve Alder's voice, and said "you promised." The players will want to know what Alder traded and why, and whether the hill is truly dead or only sleeping. That is your next session, built by this one's ending, exactly as Chapter 11 promised.

You now have two complete adventures in your kit, at two difficulty levels, plus the seeds and tables to build a dozen more. That is a campaign's worth of play from one book. Go run it.

Appendix: The Rules You'll Actually Use

This is not a tutorial. It is the reference card you keep at your elbow, the handful of numbers and lists you reach for over and over while running a game. The full rules live in the core books. What follows is the ten percent of them you touch in ninety percent of your sessions, gathered in one place so you never stop the game to go looking.

Copy these pages, or print them from the download pack, and keep them under your screen next to the Quick-Reference from the back of the book.

The six abilities, and when to call each

When a player tries something uncertain, you ask for a check. This is the map from "what they are doing" to "which ability," the same one from your ruling sheet in Chapter 4.

Strength force, lifting, breaking, grappling, climbing under load
Dexterity balance, stealth, sleight of hand, dodging, fine control
Constitution .. holding your breath, resisting poison, enduring pain and cold
Intelligence .. recalling lore, investigating clues, understanding a puzzle
Wisdom noticing, sensing a lie, tracking, reading a mood, willpower
Charisma persuading, deceiving, intimidating, performing, leading

Difficulty, at a glance

Set the number the player must meet or beat with a d20 plus their bonus. When in doubt, 15. You do not need more precision than this.

Very easy 5	Easy 10
Medium 15	Hard 20
Very hard 25	Near impossible 30

What a character can do in a combat turn

On their turn, a character can move and take one action. Knowing the common actions cold keeps combat fast, so you are not paging through a book while five people wait.

COMMON ACTIONS

Attack make one melee or ranged attack (more at higher levels)
Cast a Spell .. most spells take one action
Dash move again, double your distance
Disengage move without provoking a free hit
Dodge attackers have disadvantage against you
Help give an ally advantage on their next try
Hide make a Dexterity (Stealth) check
Use an Object . pull a lever, drink a potion, throw a torch

ALSO ON YOUR TURN

A "bonus action" if something grants one, and free talking.
One "reaction" per round, even on others' turns (like an opportunity attack when a foe leaves your reach).

Advantage and disadvantage

The game's simplest and most useful tool. When the situation clearly helps, give advantage: roll two d20 and keep the higher. When it clearly hurts, disadvantage: roll two and keep the lower. Reach for this instead of inventing bonuses. It is fast, it feels good, and it covers most of the rulings you will make.

The conditions you will actually see

When a spell or effect imposes a condition, this is the short version of what it does. You will use the top handful constantly and the rest rarely.

Prone movement costs double to stand; melee attackers get advantage
Grappled speed 0; ends if the grappler is knocked away
Restrained speed 0; attacks against it have advantage; it attacks with disadvantage
Poisoned disadvantage on attacks and ability checks
Frightened disadvantage while the source is in sight; cannot move closer to it
Blinded cannot see; attacks against it have advantage, its own have disadvantage
Stunned cannot act; attacks against it have advantage
Unconscious ... drops everything, prone; attackers have advantage, and crit in melee

Resting, the short version

Two kinds of rest let characters recover, and knowing the difference sets the pace of your adventuring day. A short rest is about an hour: characters can spend resources to heal some and recover certain abilities. A long rest is about eight hours of sleep: they regain most of their health and their spent abilities. As a rule of thumb, aim for a couple of fights between long rests, so resources matter and the day has a shape.

Death, the short version

When a character drops to zero, they are not dead yet. They make death saving throws on their turns: a 10 or higher succeeds, lower fails, three successes stabilize, three failures end them, and a natural 20 brings them back with one hit point. Any healing pulls them back to their feet. This buffer is on purpose. It gives the table a tense moment and their friends a chance to act, instead of a single roll deciding a character's story.

Keep this near

None of this replaces reading the core rules once. It replaces looking things up mid-scene, which is where new DMs lose the room. Glance here, make the call, keep the game moving. After a dozen sessions you will not need the card, because it will be in your head, put there by the only teacher that works: playing.

Quick-Reference: The Table Screen

Tear these pages out, or copy them from the download pack, and keep them where you sit. Everything here is meant for use during play, not prep. When the game is live and your mind goes blank, this is the page you look at.

MAKE A RULING (Chapter 4)

- 1 What are they really trying to do? 2 Which ability fits?
3 Stakes out loud (success / failure) 4 Roll, narrate, move on
Difficulty fast: Easy 10 - Medium 15 - Hard 20 (unsure? 15)

IMPROV FIRST MOVES (Chapter 5)

Repeat it back, then "yes, and" / "yes, but". Flat no only for the impossible.

WHO IS THIS NPC? – roll d20 (Chapter 5, Table A)

- 1 nervous clerk 2 talkative veteran 3 widow running the trade
4 official wanting a bribe 5 cheerful liar 6 youth in over their head
7 blunt laborer 8 odd peddler 9 drunk who saw something real
10 sure believer 11 grieving parent 12 old rival 13 gossip for coin
14 guard who hates the job 15 healer low on supplies 16 obsessed collector
17 reformed criminal 18 stern elder 19 charmer with an angle 20 fearful outsider

WHAT COMPLICATES THIS? – roll d20 (Chapter 5, Table B)

- 1 watcher in shadow 2 rival group 3 true but incomplete 4 a painful price
5 wrong person overhears 6 less time than they thought 7 old enemy involved
8 a lie unravels 9 terrain turns 10 contact switched sides 11 reinforcements
12 target has fled 13 trap for someone else 14 a debt comes due 15 goals conflict
16 witness wants something 17 the way is guarded 18 someone is recognized
19 reward isn't as promised 20 a sound draws attention

ENCOUNTER BUDGET (Chapter 7)

Standard = one threat point per player. Easy = half. Hard = players x1.5.
One point ≈ a monster at the party's level. Mix sizes. Turn a danger lever:
terrain / reinforcements / an exit.

FIVE-ROOM LOCATION (Chapter 8)

- 1 entrance+guardian 2 puzzle/roleplay 3 setback 4 climax 5 reward+twist

KEEP IT MOVING (Chapter 9)

Plot facts are found automatically. Three clues to every conclusion.
When they stall, start a clock. End the night on a question.

INSTANT NAMES

Bren - Kesh - Mira - Doran - Sela - Tomas - Aurelian - Vespera - Ysolde
Grud - Nix - Halla - Vane - Sump - Castellan

Get the printable pack

Every template and table in this book is waiting as a clean, printable, fillable pack. It is free, and it is built to sit next to you while you run a game. The First-Session Checklist, the 1-Hour Prep Worksheet, the Improv Toolkit, the Encounter and Location sheets, the Quick-Reference screen: all of it, ready to print.

Scan the code below or visit the link to download it.

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If you found this book useful, a short review helps another first-time DM find it, and it helps more than you would guess. Thank you, and good gaming.

About the author

Cedric Darkstone has helped new Game Masters run their first sessions for years, turning nervous first-timers into confident storytellers. He writes practical guides for people who would rather do the thing than read about it. *First-Time Dungeon Master* is the book he wishes someone had handed him before his own first, slightly disastrous, wonderful session.